



BEFORE

In earliest times, much religion seems to have been related to fertility or the seasons. As people's social organization changed, so did their conception of their gods.

EARLIEST SUPERNATURAL BELIEFS

Remains of Stone Age ritual burials << 32–33 suggest that belief in the **afterlife** and the **spirit world** is at least 60,000 years old. Neolithic monuments and traces of ritual life << 40–41 suggest a spiritual outlook reflecting the **cycle of seasons** and the **motion of the heavens**.

PREHISTORIC RELIGIOUS SYMBOLS

Religious artifacts from prehistoric societies << 34–35 reveal more about beliefs, despite the lack of written evidence. Male and female figurines with exaggerated features may be related to a desire for **fertility and prosperity**. Ritual sites that contain animals—either their physical remains, or images—suggest the worshippers were preoccupied with the supply of **animals for food and materials**.

HIERARCHY OF GODS

Early religion often involved **polytheism—the worship of many deities**. With the emergence of more complex societies in the first towns << 44–45, the new social order was mirrored in religion: the gods were organized, like society, into a **hierarchy**, with the ruling god at the apex.

IDEAS

HUMANS BECOMING GODS

Individuals with power over others were sometimes given the status of a god. The deified ruler may have been seen as the earthly embodiment of a certain god, or may have been worshipped as a god in their own right, giving his or her subjects protection in return. Rulers deified in their lifetime or after their deaths became more common in the Mediterranean world after the 4th century BCE. Below, the Roman emperor Claudius is being deified right after his death in 54 CE.



Greek gods

Found in the Mannella region of southeast Italy, this Greek clay sculpture from the first half of the 5th century BCE features the Greek goddess and daughter of Zeus, Persephone, and the god of the underworld, Hades.

